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ETHICS & FEASIBILITY SAMPLE

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ResearchEdit4U — Ethics & Feasibility Pack

SAMPLE – NOT FOR SUBMISSION • October 17, 2025

This is basically a sample ethics and feasibility support document made for a student researcher whose low-risk study was sent back by the ethics committee for revision. In very simple terms, it shows how ResearchEdit4U Solutions can help a researcher fix common ethics-related problems without doing the work for them. The sample explains the student's situation, the kind of study they are doing, why the study is considered low risk, who can participate, and how consent should be taken in a short, clear, easy-to-understand way. It also shows how to safely handle participant data, recruit people fairly, and prepare a realistic small budget. On top of that, it gives simple answers to the kind of questions ethics committees usually ask, such as how risk is controlled, how privacy is protected, and how participation remains voluntary. Overall, this pack is meant to help a student understand ethics requirements in plain language, respond properly to committee comments, and resubmit their study with more confidence while still keeping full authorship and responsibility for their own work.

Illustrative topic: Hydration reminders to reduce tension-type headache days in university students with frequent headaches (low-risk, behavioural).

1 —Client’s Story, Risk Level & Participant Profile

A different, very real story

- **Ethics decision:** “Provisional—revise and resubmit”.
- Committee concerns: risk unclear; consent too long; privacy measures vague; recruitment biased; budget unrealistic.
- **Student context:** paramedic student with night shifts; deadline in 10 days; low-risk idea but little time to decode ethics jargon.
- **Chosen support:** this 4-page pack.
- **How we empowered (no ghostwriting):** two short “ethics clinic” calls; we turned red-ink into a checklist, explained minimal risk in plain words, showed how to shrink PIS/consent to half a page, and walked through privacy, anonymisation, fair recruitment, and a micro-budget. The student wrote/edited everything; we coached and mapped fixes to each committee comment.
- **Outcome:** resubmission answered each comment: risk justified, consent readable, specific data plan, fair recruitment, grounded budget, optional OSF prereg line. You retain authorship responsibility (ICMJE/COPE).

Risk level

Minimal risk behavioural study: hydration reminders + daily logs. Harm/discomfort not greater than daily life or routine exams (Common Rule, 45 CFR 46.102).

Participant profile & vulnerability checks

- Population: students 18–30 with recurrent primary headaches (exclude red-flag secondary causes).
- Vulnerability screens: 18+ only; capacity to consent; voluntary participation; simple withdrawal path; non-coercive wording; plain-language consent.

2 —Participant Information & Tick-Box Consent (exemplars)

Participant Information Sheet

- What you'll do: 2-minute baseline survey → 14 days of 3 hydration reminders/day → 1–2 minutes/day to log water intake and any headaches.
- Why this matters: Some evidence suggests better hydration can help students with frequent tension-type headaches; we are testing whether reminders help adherence.
- Risks: Minimal—possibly more toilet breaks. Stop if unwell.
- Benefits: You may notice fewer or milder headaches, but this is not guaranteed.
- Privacy: Secure storage, study ID instead of names, restricted access.
- Voluntary: You can leave anytime without penalty.
- Contacts: Study email; independent ethics office contact.

Consent checklist (18+ study)

1. I am 18+ and a current student.
2. I have read and understood what the study involves.
3. My questions were answered.
4. I understand participation is voluntary and I can withdraw anytime without penalty.
5. I agree to anonymous use of my data for research and publication.
6. I wish to take part.

3 — Data Management Plan, Recruitment & Budget

Data Management Plan (short & concrete)

- Storage: encrypted university cloud/approved drive; no personal laptops.
- Identifiers: separate encrypted ID key; analysis file uses study IDs (pseudonymised).
- Anonymisation: remove direct identifiers before sharing; check small cells to avoid re-ID; follow national anonymisation guidance.

- Retention: keep consent & ID key (e.g., 5 years per local policy); store apart from de-identified data.
- Sharing (if publishing): share de-identified dataset + readme, aligned with modern data-sharing expectations.

Access control (who sees what)

Role	Access
PI & student researcher	ID key + raw files
Supervisor	De-identified dataset only
External reviewer (if any)	Summary/anonymised sample

Keep a simple access log (date, person, file, reason).

Recruitment scripts

- Email subject: “2-week hydration reminder study for frequent headaches (voluntary; 1–2 min/day).”
- Body: one paragraph in plain English + inclusion/exclusion bullets + non-coercive tone + link/QR.
- Fairness note: send to broad student lists; cap weekly enrolment; avoid first-come bias; participation will not affect courses or services.
- Poster: simple call-to-action + QR code; include ethics approval number once issued.

Budget micro-sheet

Scenario	Items
Low (₹0–₹2k)	Univ. survey tool; digital posters; no incentives
Base (₹2k–₹6k)	Printing; small thank-you; secure storage add-on
High (₹6k–₹15k)	Reminder app licence; pro poster design; stats consult hour

Resource plan: student setup 1 day; collection 14 days; clean & analyse 2–3 days; two 30-min supervisor check-ins.

4 — Ethics Form Q&A (annotated) & Integrity Bar

Typical committee Q&As (with tips)

- Justify risk level: Minimal risk; activities mirror daily life; exclude red-flag headaches; voluntary participation; clear stop rules. Tip: quote the Common Rule definition in the form.
- How will consent be obtained? Online consent after half-page PIS; questions via email/WhatsApp; readable to students (no legalese).

9. How will privacy be protected? Encrypted storage; separate ID key; role-based access; anonymise before sharing (per ICO guidance).
10. How will recruitment be fair? Open call to eligible students; weekly cap; non-coercive script; clear opt-out.
11. Is the budget realistic? Three bands with line-item justifications; minimal hidden costs.

Integrity bar

- Authorship: Follow ICMJE—4 criteria (contribution; drafting/review; final approval; accountability).
- AI boundaries: COPE—AI tools are not authors; disclose limited assistive use transparently.
- Transparency boost (optional): OSF preregistration (time-stamped plan before data collection).

Key sources (for your reference list)

Common Rule minimal risk — 45 CFR 46.102 (eCFR): <https://www.ecfr.gov/current/title-45/subtitle-A/subchapter-A/part-46/subpart-A/section-46.102>

OHRP — Consent must be understandable to participants:

<https://www.hhs.gov/ohrp/regulations-and-policy/guidance/faq/informed-consent/index.html>

ICO — Anonymisation & pseudonymisation guidance: <https://ico.org.uk/for-organisations/uk-gdpr-guidance-and-resources/data-sharing/anonymisation/>

NIH — Data Management & Sharing Policy (2023): <https://grants.nih.gov/policy-and-compliance/policy-topics/sharing-policies/dms>

ICMJE — Defining the role of authors and contributors:

<https://www.icmje.org/recommendations/browse/roles-and-responsibilities/defining-the-role-of-authors-and-contributors.html>

COPE — Authorship and AI tools (position statement):

<https://publicationethics.org/guidance/cope-position/authorship-and-ai-tools>

OSF — Registrations & preregistration help: <https://help.osf.io/article/330-welcome-to-registrations>

ICHD-3 — Tension-type headache overview: <https://ichd-3.org/2-tension-type-headache/>

THANK YOU

ETHICS & FEASIBILITY SUPPORT SAMPLE

Prepare your study with clearer ethics documentation and realistic feasibility planning.

We help researchers improve
ethics clarity • risk justification • consent
documentation • privacy safeguards • recruitment
fairness • feasibility planning

Need support preparing your ethics submission?
Send your research proposal, ethics form draft,
consent documents, or study plan and get a
Free sample ethics and feasibility review.

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